

2 Subject content

Qualification aims and objectives

The aims and objectives of this qualification are to enable students to:

- use specialist vocabulary, psychological concepts, terminology and convention to engage in the process of psychological enquiry
- acquire knowledge and understanding of psychology, developing an understanding of self and others, and how psychological understanding can help to explain everyday social phenomena
- understand how psychological research is conducted, including the role of scientific method and data analysis
- present information, develop arguments and draw conclusions through a critical approach to psychological evidence, developing as reflective thinkers
- develop an understanding of the relationship between psychology and personal, moral, social and cultural issues, and develop an understanding of ethical issues in psychology
- develop an understanding of psychological issues, the contribution of psychology to individual, social and cultural diversity, and how psychology contributes to society.

Knowledge and understanding

Students will gain knowledge and understanding of key features of the following core areas of psychology through the study of the compulsory and optional topics in this specification, including research methods:

- biological – an understanding of biological concepts in psychology, including neuroscience and genetics as contributors to behaviour
- cognitive – an understanding of thought, information and mental processing as contributors to behaviour
- social – an understanding of the social area of psychology, the impact of social and environmental factors on behaviour and the influence of groups
- developmental – an understanding of how individuals change throughout their lives, with a particular focus on childhood and how both nature and nurture can affect individuals
- individual differences – an understanding of the complex nature of human behaviour and experiences and why and how people are different.

Students will also gain knowledge and understanding of:

- debates in psychology, including 'reductionism/holism' and 'nature/nurture'
- how psychological knowledge and ideas change over time and how they inform our understanding of behaviour
- the contribution of psychology to an understanding of individual, social and cultural diversity
- the interrelationships of the core areas of psychology
- how the studies for topics relate to the associated theory
- research methods.

Content

Students are expected to demonstrate and apply the knowledge, understanding and skills described in the content.

To demonstrate their knowledge, students should undertake a range of activities, including the ability to recall, describe and define, as appropriate.

To demonstrate their understanding, students should explain ideas and use their knowledge to apply, analyse, interpret and evaluate, as appropriate.

Students will be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the interrelationships between the core areas of psychology and issues and debates within them.

Students may be asked to consider the following issues when evaluating studies:

- validity
- reliability
- generalisability
- ethics
- objectivity
- subjectivity.

The content contains three sections:

Section A: Compulsory topics

Students must study all topics in this section. These topics will be examined in Paper 1. The contexts in these topics will also be used in in Paper 2 for research methods (Topic 11: Research methods – How do you carry out psychological research?).

Section B: Optional topics

Students must study two of the topics in this section. These topics will be examined in Paper 2.

Section C: Research methods

Students must study the topic in this section. The knowledge and understanding of research methods will be assessed in both papers.

Paper 1: Students may be asked to apply their knowledge and understanding of research methods and how studies are conducted in new contexts. Any detail students need to know about a study will be detailed in the question.

Paper 2: Students' knowledge and understanding of research methods will be assessed in depth in this section. The contexts used in question papers for this topic will draw on the contexts used in the compulsory topics for Paper 1.

In the examination, students could be asked to design a research study and/or evaluate how a study has been carried out from stimulus material, drawing on any of the terms in 11.1.

Opportunities for practical activities

Students should gain hands-on experience of carrying out ethical, investigative activities to aid their understanding of this subject. To help centres identify opportunities for carrying out these activities, studies that can be replicated have been marked with an asterisk. Practical activities should also be used to deliver Section C. For example, students could produce their own questionnaires to help them understand sampling methods.

Although students will not be directly assessed on these activities, the experience they gain will give them a better understanding of this subject and may enhance their examination performance.

Mathematical requirements

Psychology requires the use of mathematical skills for handling data in investigations.

The mathematical skills required for this qualification are set out in Section 11.2 of

Topic 11: Research methods – How do you carry out psychological research?

Section A: Compulsory topics

Students must study **all** the topics in this section. These topics will be examined in Paper 1. The contexts in these topics will also be used in Paper 2 for research methods (Topic 11: Research methods – How do you carry out psychological research?).